

The Long Winter's Night

The snowlit fjords of the north run deep and blue between white mountains and dark green pines, dotted with cosy longhouses whose windows glow warm amber against the snow. Above them arches the Great World Tree, and on clear nights the sky dances with the colours of the aurora. The fjords are full of gentle wonders: a chattering squirrel who carries messages along the tree, two thoughtful ravens, light spirits who dance in the dark, and frost giants who look fearsome but are mostly just cold and lonely. Here a hero is not the strongest or the loudest, but the one who keeps a warm heart, dreams up ideas, and shares the fire. The grandest deeds are done by being brave and kind and full of ideas, and even a giant met with a friendly word often turns out lonelier than it is fierce.

The answers are here. This part is for the grown-up, not for the child.

Show the matching picture in the Atlas as you reach each place.



Read aloud, or let an older child read it themselves. Pause at each question so the heroes can decide together. There are no wrong answers here, only braver ideas to try.

Before you begin

It was the longest night of the year, the deep heart of winter, when the dark stretches on so far you begin to wonder if the sun has forgotten the way home. And on this night of all nights, the great hearth-fire of the Hearth Hall had gone out. The longhouse had fallen cold. The amber windows that always glowed across the snow were dark, and one by one, all down the valley, the warmth was slipping away.

Edda the Saga-Keeper called the two of you to her side, her old eyes bright in the gloom. "You have bright ideas and warm hearts," she said, "and on a night like this that is worth more than any axe. Will you carry the warmth back to us before dawn?"

Into your hands she pressed three gifts: the Everwarm Ember, a coal that never goes cold; a ball of bright red yarn; and a soft honey bun, still warm from the embers. "Remember," she said, "in these fjords we do not win by being the strongest. We win by being brave, kind, and full of ideas. Cross the Rainbow Bridge to the high halls, and light the world's warmth again."



What is your hero name? Which quality will you carry: Imagination, Courage, or Heart?

Stop 1 The Frozen Fjord

You stepped out under a sky thick with cold stars, and before you lay the Frozen Fjord: a long, deep arm of water turned smooth and silver between the dark mountains. It looked solid enough, but the moment you set foot on it, the ice gave a long, low groan, and somewhere beneath you something cracked and settled. To rush across all together, in one heavy bunch, would be asking too much of it.

Far overhead the Two Ravens, Thought and Memory, wheeled against the stars and watched you with patient, gentle eyes.



How will you cross without the ice giving way? Could you spread out so your weight is shared, and step softly, treating the ice gently? Could you hold hands and go together, or lay the red yarn down as a guide through the dark? What is your plan?

By spreading out and stepping gently, with the red yarn unspooling bright behind you, you crossed the fjord as kindly as you could, and the ice held you the whole way. You reached the far shore with frost on your eyelashes and your hearts beating quick and proud.

Stop 2 The Lonely Frost Giant

And there, past the fjord, sat a giant: huge, hewn from pale blue ice, taller than the Hearth Hall itself, blocking the road with his folded arms and a face set as hard as a glacier. Your heart thumped. For a moment he looked like the end of the whole adventure.

Then he shivered, and his great icy shoulders sagged, and you understood. He was not angry. He was lonely. No traveller had ever stopped to speak with him, and the long cold years alone had made him gruff and sad.

★ *This was never a fight, and no one here raises a hand. What kindness could you show him? You have a warm honey bun to share. You could ask him his name, or offer him a place beside the Everwarm Ember, or simply tell him he need not be alone tonight. What do you do?*

When you offered him your kindness, the giant's hard face cracked, not with anger but with wonder, and warmed slowly into a smile. "You stayed," he whispered, as though he could hardly believe it. "You are my friends." And he rose, gentle as falling snow, and came along beside you into the dark.

Stop 3 The Rainbow Bridge

At the foot of the mountains shimmered the Rainbow Bridge, a great arch of soft colours rising out of the snow towards the high halls of the gods. It was beautiful and a little frightening, for it was said to hold firm only for those who cross it with a kind and honest heart, and to dim and waver beneath any other.

★ *Will you cross? You carry the Everwarm Ember, warm and true, and beside you walks a friend who was lonely an hour ago and is lonely no longer. Step out together, honestly and gently, and trust the bridge to know your hearts.*

As you stepped out, the bridge brightened under your feet, colour blooming with every step, and it carried all of you, giant and all, safely up to the high hall. There you lifted the Everwarm Ember high, and its glow leapt outward, and the world's warmth caught light once more.

Dawn and Warmth

Far below, the change began. One hearth, then another, then a hundred, the fires relit themselves all down the snowy valley, until every amber window glowed warm again and the cold lost its grip on the long night. Slowly, softly, the first pale gold of dawn climbed over the white mountains, and the longest night of the year ended not in darkness but in light.

High above, the Aurora Spirits woke and danced for joy, ribbons of teal and green and purple rippling across the brightening sky. The Lonely Frost Giant stood among you, warm at last and smiling, with friends he had waited his whole long life to find. And from the high halls, Freya the Kind looked down and smiled. You had done it, and you had done it together: with your ideas, with your courage, and above all with your heart. Well done, heroes of the Snowlit Fjords.

The Long Winter's Night: Rules for the Grown-Up

New to this? Read the Guide for the Grown-Up first. It explains the whole idea in two pages and you will never need it again.

The Guide for the Grown-Up explains how the game works. This page holds only what is special about this story. A failed roll is never a defeat; nobody loses. This is a braver tale than some, set on a cold and shadowy winter's night, but good ideas and kindness still win every time, and no one is ever truly hurt.

Setting up

- Print the map. Each player puts a small figure on the Start, the Hearth Hall.
- This world has no magic. Instead each hero leans on one of three qualities: **Imagination** (dreaming up ideas), **Courage** (a steady heart in the dark), or **Heart** (caring for others). On the hero sheet, where it says magic, let each child write the quality they like best. Two different qualities work best together.
- Give each player five energy stars (five small tokens or bricks). They are spent and refilled during play.
- Set out three props if you can: a glowing token or red brick for the Everwarm Ember, a ball of string or red wool for the red yarn, and a small cake or token for the honey bun. Anything can be anything.
- Keep your dice and the dice-band table from the back of the kit beside you.

The Twist of Fate

Once at each place the players may roll for a twist; read the matching line. The Guide explains how it works.

Roll	Twist of Fate
1	Nori the Tomte pops up in his red cap and gives you one free hint.
2	You find a burst of warmth in your chest, and take back one energy star.
3	A following wind off the fjord, and the next challenge is Easy.
4	The Two Ravens, Thought and Memory, fly over and nod kindly. All is well.
5	A lucky knot in the red yarn: keep one roll to use again later.
6	The Everwarm Ember flares bright, and for a moment everyone feels brave.

How it ends

The Lonely Frost Giant on the road is the "foe", but he is no villain. He is a giant of pale ice who has simply been cold and lonely too long, and there is no fight in him to win. The tale is won not by beating him but by befriending him: a shared honey bun, a kind question, a place by the ember. He then comes along and crosses the Rainbow Bridge with the heroes, and together they relight the world's warmth at the high hall as dawn breaks. Let the kindness land; it is the whole point. See the puzzles page for the three challenges and their solutions.

The Long Winter's Night: Puzzles and Solutions

For your eyes, not the children's. Each stop lists its band, what the players need to work out, the intended solution, and a gentle fallback so a stuck child always moves forward. More than one good idea should work; reward imagination and kindness over the "right" answer.

Stop 1: The Frozen Fjord (Normal)

The challenge. The heroes must cross the Frozen Fjord, a wide sheet of ice that groans and creaks underfoot. The danger is not a monster but the ice itself, which will not take a heavy, hasty crowd all at once.

Intended solution. This is a Spatial and Logic moment. The thoughtful, kind move is to **spread out** so their weight is shared, **step gently** so they treat the ice kindly, and **cross together holding hands** so no one is left behind. Laying the **red yarn** down as a guide line, or testing the way ahead carefully, works just as well.

Fallback. If the children are unsure, have the **Two Ravens** wheel overhead and "caw" the heroes into a careful, spread-out line, or let them spend an energy star to steady their footing. Crossing slowly and gently always works, and tops up an energy star.

Make it simpler. Tiptoe across the room together like quiet, careful penguins on the slippery ice.

Stop 2: The Lonely Frost Giant (Hard, then no roll)

The challenge. A huge giant of pale blue ice sits in the road with his arms folded. He looks fearsome, and the players may feel this is a fight. It is not.

Intended solution. This is a Heart and Courage moment. The giant is simply cold and lonely; nobody ever stops to speak with him. Any genuine kindness works: sharing the **warm honey bun**, asking his name, offering him a place by the **Everwarm Ember**, telling him he need not be alone. When the children are kind, his icy face warms into a smile, he becomes their friend, and he comes along with them. There is no roll to beat him, because there is no beating him; there is only befriending him.

Fallback. If the children freeze, or want to "win" by force, have the giant shiver and ask, very quietly, "Are you cold and lonely too?" A single warm word melts him. The kindness is the whole challenge, and it cannot be failed.

Make it simpler. Give the lonely giant a big warm hug and say "you can be our friend".

Stop 3: The Rainbow Bridge (Normal)

The challenge. The shimmering Rainbow Bridge rises to the high halls, and it holds firm only for those who cross with a kind and honest heart. The heroes must cross, carrying the ember, and reach the high hall to relight the world's warmth.

Intended solution. This is a Heart and Imagination moment. Because the heroes carry the **Everwarm Ember** and now travel with the **Lonely Frost Giant** as a friend, their hearts are exactly what the bridge is looking for. Crossing honestly and gently, keeping their new friend beside them, the bridge brightens and holds. At the top they lift the ember and the world's warmth catches light again.

Fallback. If they hesitate at the edge, have the bridge glow a little warmer with each kind word they say, so a single honest "we came to bring the warmth back" lights the way across. The bridge always holds for these heroes; their hearts have already earned it.

Make it simpler. Walk a line of colourful cushions or a scarf laid on the floor, holding hands and naming a colour on each step.

The ending

There is no battle and no loser. When the ember is lifted at the high hall, every hearth-fire relights down the valley, every amber window glows again, and the longest night ends in dawn and colour. The **Aurora Spirits** dance overhead, the **Lonely Frost Giant** has friends at last, and **Freya the Kind** smiles down from the high halls. The heroes have won the only way anyone wins here, by being brave, kind, and full of ideas.

Wander and Tales

Tale Book

<https://github.com/agigante80/wander-and-tales>

Content licence: CC BY-SA 4.0 (<https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by-sa/4.0/>)

Version 6.2, updated 2026-06-06, en-GB



Scan for the latest version

Here nobody loses. If a try does not work, find another way.